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Author(s): Thomas Frentz

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Quality, Rhetoric, and Choric Regression: Revisiting *Zen* and the *Art of Motorcycle Maintenance*

Thomas Frentz

ABSTRACT

In this article, I reexamine quality and rhetoric in Robert M. Pirsig's *Zen and the Art of Motorcycle Maintenance* through Julia Kristeva's semiotic *chora*. To that end, I review three analyses of Pirsig's novel, reinscribe quality as a prediscursive experience of undifferentiated wholeness, argue that regression back into Kristeva's *chora* is one way to recover this prediscursive experience, and hypothesize that the rhetoric of *Zen* is an unstable discourse in which prediscursive energies from the *chora* disrupt and realign the meanings of signifiers. I conclude by generalizing my work beyond Pirsig's novel to three concepts in rhetorical scholarship.

KEYWORDS: rhetoric, quality, Pirsig, *chora*, Kristeva

Quality! Virtue! Dharma! That is what the Sophists were teaching!
Not ethical relativism. *Not* pristine "virtue." But *aretê*. Excellence.
Dharma! Before the Church of Reason. Before substance. Before
form. Before mind and matter. Before dialectic itself. *Quality* had
been absolute. Those first teachers of the Western world were
teaching *Quality*, and the medium they had chosen was that of
rhetoric.

—Robert M. Pirsig, *Zen and the Art of Motorcycle Maintenance*

It's been slightly less than a half century since Robert M. Pirsig's *Zen and the Art of Motorcycle Maintenance* exploded on an unsuspecting American

public. Ostensibly the story about a father and son's motorcycle trip across the American Northwest, as their journey unfolds, that story becomes only the narrative vehicle for a much more important odyssey of self-discovery. As many know, the father begins to uncover the shadowy outlines of a former self he calls Phaedrus (from Plato's dialogue of the same name), a solitary genius who went mad pursuing quality, an undifferentiated way of living that defied any and all attempts to grasp it within the binary logics of rational thought. But for rhetorical scholars everywhere, the real eye-opener was that Phaedrus came to believe that the Sophists, that same unseemly bunch vilified by Plato in many of his dialogues, once taught quality through, of all things, rhetoric.

The mad pursuit of the father/narrator and his alter ego, Phaedrus, to recover an undifferentiated lifestyle taught through rhetoric is driven by cultural fragmentation. Both characters think that the quality of American life has been compromised and corrupted by the oppressive dominance of rational thought that Phaedrus eventually believes he can trace back to Platonic dialectic. As the father/narrator discovers, the binary structure of that thought isolates people from their work, from each other, and, perhaps most important, given the psychological disconnect between the father/narrator and Phaedrus, from themselves. The father/narrator finds only small pockets of quality in rural enclaves where the toxicity of rationality does not seem to have affected the coherence of everyday life.

One reason to return to Pirsig's text is that the societal fragmentation he identified in 1974 is not only still with us but has mushroomed exponentially since then. As Thomas Rickert notes, scholars as diverse as Lacan, Derrida, and Foucault all argue that the decentering capacities of language undermine any stable sense of individual identity, cultural coherence, or societal homogeneity (2007a, 36). Moreover, Lacan's famous "mirror stage" of psychological development specifies the origin of what he calls the split subject. "What I have called the 'mirror stage' . . . manifests the affective dynamism by which the subject primordially identifies with the visual gestalt of its own body. In comparison with the still very profound lack of coordination in his own motor functioning, that gestalt is an ideal unity, a salutary *imago*" (2006, 92). When this split subject (the body and its ideal) enters language, it becomes a signifier whose identity is localized in its difference from other subjects-as-signifiers. Thus, a split subject becomes a subject of/in language when she or he is given a name (signifier) like "Louise" or "Lester" whose "identity" is only that Louise is not Lester and Lester is not Louise. As Lacan says, "a signifier is what represents the

subject to another signifier" (2006, 694). Here, language not only shatters any unified individual identity but totally redefines it in terms of difference. That seems to be a pretty severe form of fragmentation.

I need to issue two caveats here. First, Pirsig and many poststructural thinkers differ on the value of fragmentation. Pirsig, obviously, believes it depreciates all aspects of life, whereas a number of contemporary scholars see it as a positive development that paves the way for new forms of freedom from and resistance to social oppression. Even given their different perspectives on its value, however, both agree that fragmentation is an ever-increasing social reality. Second, Pirsig is quite clear that addressing cultural fragmentation first entails addressing personal fragmentation. The father/narrator says, "Programs of a political nature are important *end products* of social quality that can be effective only if the underlying structure of social values are right. The place to improve the world is first in one's heart and head and hands, and then work outward from there" (2006, 381). Like many in the 1970s, Pirsig advocates an "inside-out" solution to social fragmentation whereby societal cohesion can only follow from the actions of an undifferentiated self-sense.

A second reason to reconsider *Zen* is that both the Zen-like state of quality and the analogue of Sophistic rhetoric that could, collectively, redress the fragmentation problem are never very clearly set forth in the text. For example, as a preintellectual awareness, quality seems to invite some form of Zen-like meditation, a way of anesthetizing the mind so that some holistic wisdom might emerge, but neither the father/narrator nor Phaedrus ever go there. Rather, they speak of an intense caring about what one is doing and assume that the caring can reintegrate the subject who acts with the object that is acted on (2006, 353). As useful as that kind of caring might be, it seems woefully inadequate to suture societal divisions back into an undifferentiated state. The rhetoric in *Zen* is equally obscure. Over the course of the novel, we learn of four things that it is not. First, it is not the imitative compositional practices still taught in many English Departments today (239–51). Second, it is anything but the debased form that Plato both constructs and then demolishes in the *Gorgias* (473–75). Third, although at first it appears similar to Plato's ideal rhetoric as set forth in the *Phaedrus*, it ends up not being that either (495–504). And finally, it is the antithesis of anything and everything that Aristotle ever said about the art in his *Rhetoric* (462–65). But learning what rhetoric is not doesn't help clarify what it is.

And so if today's problem is that people are still divided from all aspects of life, and if the twin solutions offered in *Zen*—namely, quality and

rhetoric—are not clear, then it seems reasonable to reenter Pirsig's text and try to rework those two solutions. The question, of course, is how to rethink quality and rhetoric in a way that both preserves the novel's original insights yet clarifies and extends them so that they might still be useful today. I want to approach that question somewhat obliquely. In the year that that *Zen* was first published, Julia Kristeva's now classic *La révolution du langage poétique* (*Revolution in Poetic Language*) was likewise published in France. On the surface, the two books couldn't be more different. *Zen* is a multilayered, quasi-autobiographical novel, while *Revolution* is a highly technical, rigorously reasoned theory of a prediscursive language. Moreover, Pirsig is interested in sophistic rhetoric, while Kristeva's subject is avant-garde poetry—and whatever else Gorgias may have been, he was neither Mallarmé nor Lautréamont.

But on a deeper level, some intriguing parallels emerge. For one, both Pirsig and Kristeva attack a hegemonic ideology. For Pirsig the ideology is the dominance of rational thought in everyday life, while for Kristeva it is the totalizing effect of Lacan's language update of Freudian psychoanalysis. For another, both attempt to resist that ideology through the recovery of something lost. *Zen* lobbies for a return to the holistic life of antiquity as instilled in sophistic rhetoric, while *Revolution* seeks out the traces of a protolanguage within discourse. Given these suggestive parallels, might Kristeva's protolanguage be related in productive ways to quality and rhetoric in *Zen*? That's the question that I want to address in this article.

I begin by looking at what three scholars have had to say about quality and rhetoric in *Zen* claiming that because none theorizes quality adequately, none grasps the novel's radical take on rhetoric as well. I then go back to *Zen* itself, not only to recover the original meaning of quality but also to argue that the root cause of its demise was not Platonic dialectic, as the father/narrator and Phaedrus claim, but rather the much older grammatical structure of Western language itself. Next, I overview Kristeva's theory of that protolanguage, arguing that it may well comprise one form of quality before the onset of language. And finally, I show how the rhetoric in *Zen* emerges when protolanguage energies and linguistic signifiers collide and conjoin to produce an ecstatic form of discourse that fuses rhetor and audience.

THREE COMMENTARIES ON QUALITY AND RHETORIC IN *ZEN*

Perplexed by the shroud of mystery surrounding quality and rhetoric in *Zen*, many scholars tried to figure out just what they might mean. Rather than provide truncated accounts of a large number of those scholarly works,

I focus in some depth on three studies that concentrate on the rhetoric in *Zen* but only pay passing attention to quality.

In 1975, Tom Farrell and I got in on the ground floor of those intrigued by the novel. Like many early commentators, we praised the work both for selling philosophy so effectively under the guise of literary fiction and for “dramatizing the euphoria of intellectual discovery in a manner as enlightening as it is exciting” (1975, 26). But we were bothered when Pirsig equated what came first (the Sophists who taught rhetoric) with what was best (*aretê* in Greek life), because what is first is not always what is best (26). Being even more bothered by what he didn’t say about that elusive art of rhetoric, we attempted to reconstruct our own version.

If we piece together such a conception from the fragments offered in *Zen*, what emerges is rhetoric as a verbal analogue to the Zen exercise of contemplative meditation. Rhetoric is a means of achieving, communicatively, a oneness among all things; it is a vehicle of optimal self-actualization. Viewed in this way, the narrator’s rhetoric of *Quality* is a communicative head trip replete with all the dangers which accompany any sustained head trip. (26)

Like many, we lauded the innovative strategy of embedding philosophy within an autobiographical storyline, but we were disappointed by Pirsig’s lack of argumentative rigor when dealing with important intellectual matters within that storyline.

However, with the benefit of forty plus years of hindsight, I think we were wrong more than we were right. For the most part, we were too often blinded by our own academic commitment to the very rational logics that Pirsig so effectively dismantles throughout *Zen*. And because of that, we had very little to say about quality itself, often diminishing it to an adjective that specifies “good” rhetoric. We were closer in our provisional reconstruction of this “rhetoric of *Quality*” as an art capable of revealing “a oneness among all things,” but since “a oneness among all things” is what *Zen*’s Phaedrus links to quality as preintellectual awareness, it’s not clear how the rhetoric we envisioned could promote it. We compounded this problem by linking that rhetoric, rather condescendingly I might add, to self-actualization, self-help manuals, and head trips (alluding to the hallucinogenic forms so popular in the 1970s) rather than elaborating on how it might function to reveal a world of undifferentiated wholeness as an important form of public address.

Two years later, Scott Consigny offered up a fuller account of the rhetoric in *Zen*. Initially using the motorcycle itself as an extended example, Consigny argues that the rider/subject's passionate care for the bike fuses him or her with the machine/object, leading the rider to select and apply proper rational procedures for repair and maintenance (quality). But then he cautions that "our cognition . . . is grounded in and logically dependent on our emotional states" (1977, 22). To clarify those states, Consigny uses Aristotle's distinction in the *Categories* between "oppositional terms" (e.g., life and death) and "correlative terms" (e.g., brother and sister) to show that Pirsig's quality changes the subject/object distinction from oppositional to correlative (25–27).

Turning directly to rhetoric, Consigny draws a connection between Pirsig's correlative sense of the subject/object relationship and the Sophists' use of rhetoric to teach *aretê* (the correlative sense of subject/object) and Socrates's use of dialectic to discover truth (the oppositional sense of subject/object). For Pirsig and the Sophists, rhetoric teaches the art of living well in a changing world, where, as Protagoras knew, humanity and not truth is the measure of all things. Socrates, of course, sees things differently. Rejecting the relativism inherent in sophistic rhetoric, Socrates envisions the "truth of the good" as an eternal idea known only to an elite group of philosophers, who could apprehend that truth through dialectic. Consigny writes, "For Pirsig, Quality is prior to our conception of subjects and objects, and hence is prior to our knowledge about these entities. *Emotional engagement is our primordial way of knowing and being*. For Socrates, in contrast, the Good becomes an aspect of the True, the absolute totality of knowledge and existence" (30).

Consigny sees clearly that quality comes before any distinction between subjects and objects. He also sees that the sophistic rhetoric in *Zen* must somehow honor that identity of subjects and objects. But he then equates quality with emotional engagement, which earlier in the novel the father/narrator calls "Romantic understanding" and defines as "primarily inspirational, imaginative, creative, intuitive. Feelings rather than facts predominate" (2006, 85). Elevating romantic understanding over classical understanding, emotional engagement over underlying structure, preserves (although it reverses) the very opposition Phaedrus is trying to collapse. For if quality integrates romantic and classical understanding, creating an undifferentiated whole, then the rhetoric that accompanies that integration must preserve it. Unfortunately, Consigny's rhetoric does not preserve it; rather, he divides romantic and classical understanding by temporalizing them,

arguing that emotional engagement precedes, grounds, and is logically prior to intellectual understanding. By contrast, the rhetoric in *Zen*, like the quality that it teaches, is an art in which no distinction exists between fact and feeling; they are both undifferentiated parts of a larger whole.

Eleven years after Consigny published his article, Geoffrey Galt Harpham had another go at it. In a richly textured and fascinating work, Harpham identifies four central figures in and around *Zen*—namely, the speaker of the Chautauqua (the father/narrator), the author of fragments from intellectual sources and pursuer of quality (Phaedrus), the author of *Zen* (Pirsig), and the readers of the work. He then argues that “*Zen* is an aggressively duplicitous text that seductively represents itself as the speech of another in order to procure the survival of its author at the expense of its reader” (1988, 78).

According to Harpham, Phaedrus’s gradual co-optation of the voice of *Zen* from the father/narrator is closely related to rhetoric and to the structure of Plato’s *Phaedrus*. Echoing Stanley Fish’s conclusion that, ultimately, the *Phaedrus* makes no sense because it annuls each move that it makes until, in the end, the dialogue becomes completely self-effacing, Harpham argues that this is so “if only because rhetoric is internally cloven and self-subverting. But if truth is systematically subverted by rhetoric, then rhetoric is equally subverted by truth” (80). Whatever else it might be, Fish’s and, by extension Harpham’s, vision of rhetoric here is not the rhetoric of *Zen*.

But Harpham has a more complex vision in mind than the one suggested by Fish, and this one, somewhat ironically, is still tied closely to Plato’s *Phaedrus*. In comparing sophistic rhetoric to Socratic dialectic, Harpham adopts a similar approach to Consigny, but unlike Consigny, who leans toward the sophists, Harpham sides with Socrates. The key to how *Zen* uses rhetoric to undermine truth is found, Harpham tells us, in those parts of the *Phaedrus* that the Phaedrus in *Zen* represses. Referencing the period in *Zen* when Phaedrus is a doctoral student at the University of Chicago, Harpham writes, “like many graduate students, Phaedrus seems deliberately to avoid enlightenment. . . . [H]e is altogether blind to the larger concern [of the *Phaedrus*], a broad rehabilitation of rhetoric as an instrument of truth” (76). Harpham here seems to take “enlightenment” to mean knowledge of the truth as set forth by Socrates in Plato’s dialogue. In his very selective reading of the *Phaedrus*, *Zen*’s Phaedrus misses its most important “truth,” which for Harpham is that “there is no opposition between dialectic and rhetoric at all. In fact, the *Phaedrus* is so remarkably plain on this count that one would think that any reader, much less

any partisan of rhetoric, would respond to Socrates's eloquent and highly rhetorical defense of rhetoric" (76–77).

But repression and blindness can cut two ways. For just as *Zen's* Phaedrus may well have repressed those parts of Plato's *Phaedrus* that might question the incommensurability Phaedrus sees between rhetoric and dialectic, so too does Harpham ostensibly repress those parts of *Zen* that might contradict his own agenda of reaffirming the identity of rhetoric and dialectic through truth in the *Phaedrus*. For example, Harpham skips over how Phaedrus historicizes rhetoric and dialectic in his continuing attempt to uncover the "real" reason Plato hated the Sophists and rhetoric. Phaedrus says:

Plato's hatred of the rhetoricians was part of a much larger struggle in which the reality of the Good, represented by the Sophists, and the reality of the True, represented by the dialecticians, were engaged in a huge struggle for the future mind of man. Truth won, the Good lost, and that is why today we have so little difficulty accepting the reality of truth and so much difficulty accepting the reality of Quality, even though there is no more agreement in one area than in the other. (2006, 477)

Harpham misses how, for Phaedrus, the struggle between the Sophists and the dialecticians over rhetoric was only a small part of a larger, much more important cultural battle between the advocates of eternal truth (the dialecticians) and those of transitory good (the Sophists).

And because Harpham ignores that passage in *Zen*, he also fails to see, or fails to see as important, what Phaedrus maintains Plato does to the good, *aretê*, both in his overall philosophy and, more centrally, in the *Phaedrus* in order to ensure that the truth trumps the good once and for all.

Plato *hadn't* tried to destroy *aretê*. He had *encapsulated* it; made a permanent, fixed Idea out of it; had *converted* it to a rigid, immobile Immortal Truth. He made *aretê* the Good, the highest form, the highest Idea of all. It was subordinate only to Truth. . . . Plato's Good was *taken* from the rhetoricians. . . . The difference was that Plato's was a fixed and eternal and unmoving Idea, whereas for the rhetoricians it was not an Idea at all. The Good was not a *form* of reality. It was reality itself, ever changing, ultimately unknowable in any kind of fixed, rigid way. (487)

While it is undoubtedly true that Plato has Socrates resort to some form of rhetoric to make the case for the ideal rhetoric in the *Phaedrus*, neither the form that Plato puts into Socrates's mouth nor the ideal that Socrates advocates (grounded in the truth) captures the sophistic rhetoric in *Zen* that Phaedrus is trying to resurrect.

Taken together, none of the three attempts to theorize the rhetoric in *Zen* does so adequately because none gives serious enough attention to what the father/narrator and Phaedrus mean by insisting that quality is inextricably linked to rhetoric. Farrell and I use the term "quality" as little more than an adjective modifying rhetoric, Harpham virtually ignores it and concentrates on rhetoric and dialectic in the *Phaedrus*, while Consigny correctly defines quality as an undifferentiated wholeness but then redefines it incorrectly as emotional understanding. If any adequate interpretation of the rhetoric in *Zen* depends on an equally adequate interpretation of quality in *Zen*, then it seems imperative to return to the text and see what the father/narrator and/or Phaedrus might have meant by quality.

PREINTELLECTUAL QUALITY

Because of its importance, I want to quote at some length how the father/narrator presents Phaedrus's first discovery of quality:

He'd [Phaedrus] been speculating about the relationship of Quality to mind and matter and had identified Quality as the parent of mind and matter, that event that gives birth to mind and matter. . . . He simply meant that at the cutting edge of time, before an object can be distinguished, there must be a kind of nonintellectual awareness, which he called awareness of Quality. You can't be aware that you've seen a tree until *after* you've seen the tree, and between the instant of vision and the instant of awareness there must be a time lag. We sometimes think of that time lag as unimportant. But there's no justification for thinking that the time lag is unimportant—none *whatsoever*. . . . The past exists only in our memories, the future in our plans. The present is our only reality. . . .

Any intellectually conceived object is *always* in the past and therefore *unreal*. Reality is always the moment of vision *before* the intellectualization takes place. There is no other reality. This preintellectual reality is what Phaedrus felt he had properly identified

as Quality. Since all intellectually identifiable things must emerge *from* this preintellectual reality, Quality is the *parent*, the *source* of all subjects and objects. (314–15)

A preintellectual awareness, a moment in time before some holistic presence gets carved up into subjects and objects, becomes the key to understanding how Phaedrus first envisions quality. To even talk about quality would therefore be to frame it within the realm of subjects and objects, and that would be to talk about something other than quality. Talking about the Buddha creates the same problem. Put somewhat differently, because the intelligibility of language is predicated on distinguishing subjects from objects, all forms of linguistic expression would be some form of “postintellectual awareness” and would miss what Phaedrus meant by quality as a prediscursive mind-state. As Phaedrus eventually comes to see, he can talk about what quality is *like* through analogy but never define what it *is* through reason.

However, this momentary lag between the apprehension of pure quality and its subsequent obliteration by language is only Phaedrus’s intellectual vision of quality, and that’s only one part of the overall picture. The other part emerges when the father/narrator discusses quality in a more practical way as an intense form of caring. He says, “I think it’s important now to tie care to Quality by pointing out that care and quality are the internal and external aspects of the same thing. A person who sees Quality and feels it as he works is a person who cares. A person who cares about what he sees and does is a person who’s bound to have some characteristics of Quality” (353). The father/narrator later ties caring to the Zen notion of inner peace of mind, a state, he tells us, “that has no relationship to external circumstances. It can occur to a monk in meditation, to a soldier in heavy combat or to a machinist taking off that last ten-thousandth of an inch. It involves unself-consciousness, which produces a complete identification with one’s circumstances” (378). In talking about quality in autoethnographic writing, I once characterized it this way: “I am not the subject-who-writes, the story is not the narrative-being-written, but they are one and the same and grow out of the Quality event. Looked at in this way, Quality is not hard to understand. It is really captured in the expression, ‘losing ourselves in our work’” (2008, 20).

Given what quality is in the novel, what diminishes it and, by so doing, ushers in the fragmented postmodern world? Although both Phaedrus and the father/narrator trace the decline of quality to the onset of dialectic (479–80), they seem to intuit that the root cause might actually predate

dialectic. This is seen most clearly where the father/narrator summarizes Phaedrus's "mythos over logos" argument.

The term *logos*, the root word of "logic," refers to the sum total of our rational understanding of the world. *Mythos* is the sum total of the early historic and prehistoric myths which preceded the logos. The mythos includes not only the Greek myths but the Old Testament, the Vedic Hymns and the early legends of all cultures which have contributed to our present world understanding. The mythos-over-logos argument states that our rationality is shaped by these legends, that our knowledge today is in relation to these legends as a tree is in relation to the little shrub it once was. One can gain great insights into the complex structure of the tree by studying the much simpler shape of the shrub. (449)

The father/narrator goes on to say that a sharp distinction between subject and object ran through the grammar of the old Greek mythos and was, as such, strongly instilled in the minds of the people who spoke its languages (449).

But if the subject-object distinction was already inherent in the subject/predicate/object structure of pre-Socratic ancient languages, then that distinction was in place long before the Greek philosophers, long before Socrates, and long before dialectic. The grammatical structure of the Greek language, not Socratic dialectic, was the source of the conceptual distinctions in Greek culture and philosophy that led to the ascension of reason as the sole avenue to truth and, by extension, to the debasement of quality in Greek life. And that means that the pathway beyond the binary splits that bedevil both Phaedrus and the father/narrator may well pass *through* dialectic, but it must begin by transgressing the underlying structure of Western language itself.

Ironically, there is a moment in the novel where the father/narrator witnesses an instance of quality in everyday life, acknowledges it, but never pursues it further. He discovers a crack in the chain guard of his cycle that he can't repair himself because he doesn't have the right tools with him. He finally comes across someone in Grant's Pass, Oregon, who can do the job. As the grizzled old man prepares to do the work, the father/narrator is caught by surprise:

He picks up a steel filler rod and I wonder if he's actually going to try to *weld* that thin metal. Sheet metal I don't weld. I braze

it with a brass rod. When I try to weld it I punch holes in it and then have to patch them up with huge blobs of filler rod. . . . He sparks the torch, and sets up a tiny little blue flame and then, it's hard to describe, actually dances the torch and the rod in separate little rhythms over the thin sheet metal, the whole spot a uniform luminous orange-yellow, dropping the torch and filler rod down at the exact right moment and then removing them. No holes. You can hardly see the weld. "That's beautiful," I say. (457–58)

The old welder certainly cares about his craft and has peace of mind, but he has something else as well. He is able to go beyond the procedures most would use to repair a cracked chain guard (the father/narrator's "brazing") and transform an ordinary moment of technological repair into an extraordinary art form. The welder achieves a moment of oneness among self, torch, filler, and chain guard that transports him "out of this world" and into the undifferentiated world of quality.

But welding a chain guard and creating rhetorical discourse are two radically different activities. And so the question becomes, is there an analogue to this physical labor within the language of rhetoric? Or, expressed as the perennial paradox of Zen, how might language capture an ultimate truth that transcends language? A reasonable answer to this paradox would be the Zen both/and response—a form of rhetoric that is both in and out of language simultaneously.

PREINTELLECTUAL QUALITY AND THE SEMIOTIC *CHORA*

One prediscursive form of language that is simultaneously "in and out" of language is Julia Kristeva's semiotic *chora*. Although she studied with Lacan and is herself a practicing psychoanalyst, Kristeva is not an orthodox "Lacanian," meaning that while she subscribes to many of his ideas, she supplements and subverts many others. Her theory of the *chora* is one such subversion because it contests the patriarchal totality of the signifying language theorized by Lacan—namely, the acontextual, unconscious symbolic and the context-bound, quasi-conscious imaginary (Lundberg 2012, 60–67). More specifically, the *chora* incorporates the multiplicity of drives within language, most centrally within poetic language. As Judith Butler puts it, "With their insistent energy and heterogeneity, these drives disrupt the signifying function. . . . While the Symbolic is predicated on the rejection of the mother, the semiotic, through rhythm, assonance, intonations,

sound play, and repetition, re-presents or recovers the maternal body in poetic speech" (1990, 82).

Perhaps because of the historical ties between rhetoric and poetics, several scholars have theorized how the *chora* might function in the art. Thomas Rickert, for example, offers an extensive historical analysis of the *chora* as the pre-Aristotelian site of rhetorical invention, although he doesn't examine the rhetoric in *Zen*. Focusing more on its indeterminacy as a place rather than on its prediscursive forms, Rickert sees the *chora* as the beginning of beginnings. Of Plato's *Timaeus*, he writes, "The *Timaeus* thereby stages for us a new kind of beginning, one that moves from the realm of the idea to the world of generation, or from being to becoming. . . . The *chora* thereby provides Plato with a means to explain the movement from Idea to Becoming as a form of vital, robust activity" (2007b, 258). As a place of vanishing becoming, the *chora* establishes the preconditions for creative invention but then recedes so that the invention can unfold. Because of its spatial nature, Rickert notes that "the *chora* has no body of scholarship in rhetorical theory" (253), an oversight that Rickert hopes to correct.

After contrasting Plato's use of the *chora* in the *Timaeus* with Aristotle's materialization of it in the *Topoi*, Rickert turns to Kristeva, underscoring how, as the maternal starting place of life, the *chora* "is an 'archaic origin' counter to the phallogocentrism of both [the Gospel of] John and Hegel, one that reincludes repressed aspects of environmental, bodily, and relational experience. This amounts to a defetishization of the rational, masculine *logos* as the ultimate horizon of human understanding and a re-embedding of the subject in material history, bodily affect, and social networks" (261). Still, he envisions the *chora* primarily as a site where rhetorical invention might occur. As such, he says little about the invention itself, aside from the implication that it involves material history, bodily affect, and social networks.

By contrast, I want to concentrate more on how the bodily energies of the *chora* insinuate themselves within rhetorical discourse and less on the *chora* itself as the maternal site of rhetorical invention. To do that, I return to Kristeva's material sense of the *chora*. Borrowing the term from the *Timaeus*, she sees it as "discrete quantities of energy [that] move through the body of the subject who is not yet constituted as such, and, in the course of his development, they are arranged according to the various constraints imposed upon his body . . . by family and social structures" (1984, 25).

Choric energies are themselves drives that define the intrauterine contact between fetus and mother.

Drives involve pre-Oedipal semiotic functions and energy discharges that connect and orient the [infant's] body to the mother. . . . The mother's body is therefore what mediates the symbolic law organizing social relationships and becomes the ordering principle of the semiotic *chora*, which is on the path of destruction, aggressivity, and death. . . . This is to say that the semiotic *chora* is no more than the place where the subject is both generated and negated, the place where his unity succumbs before the charges and stases that produce him. (27–28)

Against Lacan, for whom drives are already within language and thereby freed from any biological dependency (Evans 1996, 46), Kristeva argues that drives are biological impulses connecting fetus and mother in an endless cycle of creation and destruction. Even after the infant is born and the choric “place” vanishes, the choric energies from that place are both preserved within and repressed by the signifiers of language (Kristeva 1980, 136; Butler 1990, 82). They survive as tonalities, rhythms, and phonetic energy dispersals that are relevant to signification, but they cannot be theorized in terms of any formal language system.

Regression into the semiotic *chora* may be one way the preintellectual quality in *Zen* can be preserved and experienced by adult subjects. Both the father/narrator and Phaedrus insist that the quality event, whether understood as the infinitesimal time gap between receiving and perceiving or as the more extended practices of “losing ourselves in our work,” must somehow bypass or transcend the subject/object opposition endemic to language. And so it seems reasonable to suggest that the quality event today is one in which that foundational subject/object opposition collapses within the undifferentiated whole of choric experience. This regression seems consistent with Rickert's idea of the *chora* as a place of rhetorical invention.

THE RHETORIC OF *ZEN*

If regression into the semiotic *chora* is one way to recover preintellectual quality, how can the rhetoric in *Zen* promote such regression? One way would be to recall that, for Kristeva, the *chora* is a place *and* a source of prediscursive energies that erupt into the signifiers of language, disrupting and realigning their meanings. These choric processes can, according to Kristeva, penetrate the structures of language in three ways, on three different levels. The first is on the phonemic level: “A phoneme, as distinctive element of meaning,

belongs to language as symbolic. But this same phoneme is involved in rhythmic, intonational repetitions; it thereby tends toward autonomy from meaning so as to maintain itself in a semiotic disposition near the instinctual drives' body; it is a sonorous distinctiveness, which therefore is no longer either a phoneme or a part of the symbolic system" (1980, 135).

The *chora* can also, at times, influence the directionality of metaphors, themselves comprised of signifiers. For example, some metaphors descend out of signifiers and toward the *chora* by privileging "down" as opposed to "up," "in" in contrast to "out," or through various maternal images like "over-ween" (Lakoff and Johnson 1980, 14–19). Finally, even certain genres of literature seem dominated by choric energies such as the carnivalesque: "Figures germane to carnivalesque language, including repetition, "inconsequential" statements . . . and nonexclusive opposition that function as empty sets or disjunctive additions, produce a more flagrant dialogism than any other discourse. Disputing the laws of language based on the 0–1 interval, the carnival challenges God, authority, and social law; insofar as it is dialogical, it is rebellious" (1980, 79). From within phonemes, through directional metaphors, and even up to and subsuming disruptive literary genres, choric indices make their presence felt within the structures of language and, by extension, rhetoric.

So what is this rhetoric that moves in and out of *Zen*? It must begin, I think, with a rhetor who cares intensely about the issue at hand and who prepares to address it with peace of mind. If these psychic conditions coalesce just right, then like the welder whose torch and filler produced an art form for repairing the chain guard, signifiers and choric energies "dance" to make possible a discourse that is the real art of rhetoric implied in *Zen*. And just as the torch and filler were never under the complete control of the old welder, the choric energies that disrupt the signifiers in language are likewise never under the complete control of the rhetor. Be that as it may, when this form of rhetoric does occur, rare though it may be, an ecstatic magic happens, as the discourse transports both rhetor and audience back to the undifferentiated *chora* of the quality event.

It's extremely important to differentiate between the rhetoric of *Zen* and other, more fragmented forms of "ecstatic" discourse typically associated with charismatic demigods. The father/narrator emphasizes a *Zen*-like interdependence among phenomena and is quite clear that the rhetoric of *Zen* is a holistic discourse in which feeling and fact, emotion and reason, are integrated. By contrast, the more debased forms of "ecstatic" discourse, no matter how effective they might be to like-minded others, are almost always personal, partial, dualistic, critical, and self-righteous. There

is, I believe, a world of difference between Martin Luther King having a dream and Donald Trump having a scheme.

Zen offers one fascinating “moment” of such rhetoric that is supplied by none other than Socrates in the *Phaedrus*. A half-mad Phaedrus, who is attending a rhetoric seminar at the University of Chicago, confronts the chairman for the Committee on Analysis of Ideas and Study of Methods (aka Richard McKeon) over the meaning of Plato’s dialogue. *Zen*’s Phaedrus confounds the chairman by showing him that Socrates had to use an analogy, the famous chariot allegory, rather than dialectical reason to tell the truth about the movement of the soul because the soul’s movement transcends reason. After his initial triumph, Phaedrus reflects: “Fantastic . . . that he [Phaedrus] should have remembered that. It just demolishes the whole dialectical position. . . . Of course it’s an analogy. Everything is an analogy. But the dialecticians don’t know that. That’s why the Chairman missed that statement of Socrates. Phaedrus has caught it and remembered it because if Socrates hadn’t stated it [as an analogy] he wouldn’t have been telling the “Truth” (501). For Phaedrus, Socrates “loses control of his reason” (dialectic) when he is forced to use an analogy (rhetoric) so as to tell the truth about the soul’s movement. I believe this is as close as *Zen* ever comes to exemplifying its rhetoric, and it flashes upon us as only a microsecond in one of the greatest “speeches” of all time.

I want to conclude this section with a more extended example of the rhetoric that I’ve been trying to theorize. This example does not come from a classical treatise or contemporary public address but rather is found in a remarkable passage Kristeva herself uses to introduce an intricate, intellectual discussion of the limited ways that patriarchal language can speak of motherhood, coupled with several detailed interpretations of those limitations in the “Madonna and Child” paintings of Giovanni Bellini. And although one might surely question whether the passage I’m about to cite is “rhetoric” in any of its traditional guises, I have been at pains to argue throughout that the rhetoric in *Zen* is anything but traditional. Significantly, this particular passage discusses the inability of language to signify the maternal fusion of fetus and mother: “Cells fuse, split, and proliferate; volumes grow, tissues stretch, and body fluids change rhythm, speeding up or slowing down. Within the body, growing as a graft, indomitable, there is an other. And no one is present, within that simultaneously dual and alien space, to signify what is going on. ‘It happens, but I’m not there.’ ‘I cannot realize it, but it goes on.’ Motherhood’s impossible syllogism” (1980, 237).

Through tortured attempts to stabilize dynamic, biological processes—fusing, splitting, growing, stretching, and so forth—signifiers strain, fail, and collapse back into their choric precedents. Moreover, there is the back and forth movement between “an other” and “another,” the presence of the space in “an other” splitting one signifier into two, its absence in “another” (my computer’s preference) closing the two back into one. In addition, read aloud, the passage replicates a rhythm very close to those very biological processes that can never be adequately signified. And the moment of division, when one splits into two, can never be witnessed, never be spoken, never be signified in language. The mother tries twice and fails both times. In both cases, the resulting sentences—“It happens, but I’m not there” and “I cannot realize it, but it goes on”—while grammatical, barely make sense. And finally, there is that subtle repudiation of rational argument itself—“Motherhood’s impossible syllogism.”

IMPLICATIONS

In trying to figure out what Pirsig’s forty-year-old solution to the problem of fragmentation brought about by language and its rational offshoots is, I have argued that experiencing quality as *Zen* represents it and developing the rhetorical discourse needed to teach it may require a psychological regression into the semiotic *chora* that, because it was originally an intra-uterine space uniting mother and fetus, is both a site of undifferentiated wholeness and an inventional place where prediscursive choric energies originate. In turn, those energies are preserved within language not as signifiers but rather as rhythms, energies, splits, repetitions, and analogical pairings between and among signifiers that disrupt and rearrange their normal patterns of signification. And when this happens, occasionally a type of rhetoric is born that is, once again, capable of reuniting rhetor and audience with an analogue to pre-Socratic *aretê*. In this final section, I want to leave *Zen* and relate choric regression and its attendant rhetoric to other issues in rhetorical scholarship.

Following the work of Emmanuel Levinas and an assortment of Continental scholars, Diane Davis has theorized an ethical, relational imperative that occurs before signification and is the very condition of possibility for such signification. She seeks to

expose a sort of commonality oblivious to borders . . . that precedes and exceeds symbolic identification and therefore any prerequisite

for belonging; or, put another way: the goal is to expose an originary (or preoriginary) rhetoricity—an *affectability* or *persuadability*—that is the condition for symbolic action. . . . The task: to examine the implications of this always prior relation to the foreign(er) without which no meaning-making or determinate (symbolic) relation would be possible. (2010, 2)

Davis argues that because this relational precondition to symbolic meaning cannot be reduced to such meaning, rhetorical scholars have overlooked its importance.

Borrowing a train metaphor from Jean-Luc Nancy, Davis contrasts “being with” and “being for.” If unrelated passengers occupy the same compartment on a train they are “being with” one another, exposed to one another but not related. But as soon as one person looks at another, as soon as there is some face-to-face connection, “being with” the other becomes “being for” the other in a very particular sense. As Davis puts it, “The capacity for indifference drops off in the shift toward the ‘face,’ where ‘I’ am trapped, taken hostage. The relation with the face is a relation of nonindifference . . . that pivots neither on shared meaning nor on identification but on an obligation, an imperative that precedes understanding” (11). And it doesn’t matter if, once obligated and held hostage, the passenger ignores the face, responds pleasantly, or even reacts with hostility—the facial imperative is nevertheless both the precondition and the obligation for any type of symbolic response.

In critiquing the sufficiency of Steven Mailloux’s “rhetorical hermeneutics,” Davis expands the “being for” imperative by linking it to the *saying* of something that is *said*. She says, “The said indicates the realm of conceptual forms, themes, ideas (signified meaning); it thus offers itself up to interpretation. The saying, by contrast, indicates a nonreferential performative intrusion, an address that necessarily unsettles what is congealed in the already said. . . . The saying names the site of my encounter and exposure to the other *as* other . . . which by definition leaves my hermeneutic aspirations in the dust” (68–69).

As the preinterpretive form of “being for,” saying seems to resonate quite closely with Kristeva’s *chora* as the prediscursive prelude to language whose energies often function to disrupt symbolic meanings and thus seems to echo *Zen’s* Phaedruss’s insistence that choric rhetoric is more than and other than symbolic expression. However, given her insightful use of Freud’s theory of identification to critique Kenneth Burke’s notion

that people are genetically divided at birth so that rhetoric might symbolically identify them, it is curious that Davis doesn't extend her analysis past Freud, through Lacan (whose work she seems to know), to Kristeva when she distinguishes between the "saying" and the "said."

Perhaps more important, and more problematic, by contrasting the "saying" with the "said," Davis reproduces the very binary distinctions that *Zen's* Phaedrus is trying to collapse. As Davis surely knows, the said is already within the saying, just as for Derrida writing is always already within speech. Kristeva's argument that the *chora* is repressed by symbolic language but then erupts within it would seem to integrate the saying with the said into a single, albeit complex, speech act whose meaning would be a function of the clash of choric energies and language signifiers, or, in Davis's terms, a clash of the saying with the said. Put somewhat differently, to rethink Davis's distinction within choric rhetoric would be to suggest that the saying that obligates a relationship and the said that expresses a meaning would operate simultaneously, thereby collapsing the binary distinction between the two and allowing for the possibility that the saying and the said could interact to produce something in excess of either.

Although I take issue with Geoffrey Harpham's claim that rhetoric and dialectic are ultimately equated in the *Phaedrus*, there are two concepts in that dialogue that *Zen's* Phaedrus does ignore but that would actually have enhanced his view of both quality and rhetoric and vice versa. I refer to that elusive type of memory called *anamnesis* and to the fourth type of madness that Socrates calls "divine." For Socrates, *anamnesis* is not the capacity to remember specific cultural events (that would be *hypomnesis*) but rather the ability to withdraw from such events so as to remember the oneness of the cosmos that all souls once knew before they became embodied. Socrates also maintains that fragments of this holistic self-knowledge already exist in those cultural events themselves, the trick being to locate, recognize, and use them to activate *anamnesis* as a prelude to self-knowledge. In the dialogue, Socrates uses Phaedrus for just that purpose. As Charles L. Griswold Jr. puts it, "*In anamnesis we are both recalled to a sense of our primordial status, our place in the cosmos as a whole. . . . Anamnesis is in part a description of how someone who already understands language in the ordinary way can understand the truth of things, that is, see them in their context as a whole*" (1986, 114–15).

Anamnesis in the *Phaedrus* seems very close to how I've characterized choric regression as the pathway to quality in *Zen*. Genuine insight into anything, the father/narrator says over and over, occurs as an instantaneous discovery, when reason stalls and shuts down, making it possible for new

knowledge to erupt through some intuitive analogy probably unleashed from the unconscious (2006, 331–44). *Anamnesis* is a remembrance of cosmic wholeness before embodiment. Now clearly, a fetus in its mother's womb is already embodied to some extent, but the regressive process that I've described here seems quite similar to Socrates's *anamnesis*.

Moreover, that process itself, because it transports a person out of the material world of the present and back into the undifferentiated world of the womb, could easily be seen as a form of divine madness (although modern psychology might wince at the "divine" part). The idea of this regression as a kind of madness is suggested in *Zen*—after the father/narrator and Phaedrus are divided, the father/narrator comes to regard Phaedrus as clinically insane (78–79), but when they reunite at the end of the novel and the father/narrator's son Chris asks, "Were you really insane?" the reintegrated father/narrator/Phaedrus answers emphatically, "No!" (526). If we were to map *Zen's* Phaedrus back onto the various forms of madness discussed in the *Phaedrus*, *Zen's* Phaedrus, like Socrates before him, would surely be divinely mad, and, as Socrates says, that's a very good thing to be, a state experienced by only a very few souls. And so, as Harpham suggests, perhaps Phaedrus should have read a few more sections of the *Phaedrus* a bit more carefully, not because doing so would have led him to see that Socrates's ideal rhetoric is identical to dialectic (it isn't) but rather because it would have showed him how his own insights into quality and rhetoric might have been enriched by both divine madness and *anamnesis*. In turn, ideas like *anamnesis* and divine madness that remain pivotal to understanding the *Phaedrus* may well be enriched by the notion of choric regression and its concomitant rhetoric.

Finally, there is a person who seems to have prefigured and personified the choric regression of quality and its attendant rhetoric I've sketched here and who did so before the advent of either Sophistic rhetoric or Platonic dialectic. Ironically, that person is even mentioned in *Zen*. In his search for the historical roots of dialectic, *Zen's* Phaedrus encounters Parmenides's stance on the immortal principle.

Parmenides made it clear for the first time that the Immortal Principle, the One, Truth, God is separate from appearance and from opinion, and the importance of this separation and its effect upon subsequent history cannot be overstated. It's here that the classic mind, for the first time, took leave of its romantic origins and said, 'The Good and the True are not necessarily the same,' and

goes its separate way. Anaxagoras and Parmenides had a listener named Socrates who carried their ideas into full fruition. (479)

Although it might be condensed and overdramatized here for effect, according to Thomas Rickert's recent work on Parmenides, *Zen's* Phaedrus's take on him is in line with that of most classical scholars (2014, 475–76). By contrast, Rickert radicalizes Parmenides, calling him a performer, healer, and knower of rhetorical principles and, perhaps most important, claiming that his sophisticated logical techniques came through revelations from the goddess Persephone and not from the inferential entailments of reasoned thought (474). He was, Rickert tells us, "someone interested in the inner continuity between the world's cosmology and life's betterment" (474). Rickert sees Parmenides as representing a "prehistory" of rhetoric that "seeks more fluid and dynamic relations between contrasting categories such as rational and non-rational, human and nonhuman, and rhetoric and philosophy that too often substitute for settled knowledge" (474).

Focusing on the oft-ignored proem of Parmenides's philosophical poem "On Being," Rickert traces how Parmenides is led by *mares* (women) to maidens who, in turn, escort him to the underworld where he meets Persephone, from whom he receives revelatory wisdom (480). Rickert emphasizes that in the proem, "Parmenides is describing a *katabasis*, a descent into revelation, not an ascent into rational truth" (480). This is the opposite of Plato's cave myth in the *Republic* in which the cave contains only illusions, and escape from the cave into the light of day illuminates truth (480–81). Metaphorically, Plato's road to truth is from darkness into light, whereas Parmenides's is from light into darkness (481). In Rickert's words, "Parmenides practiced incubation. . . . He would lie down in a cave, like Epimenides and Orpheus before him, and incubate, and with his visions came wisdom. . . . The transformative, even magical, power of words was a lived experience in the ancient world. It therefore makes sense that Parmenides's work would seek to evoke the revelatory experience it describes in its audience" (483–84).

What emerges in Rickert's insightful characterization of Parmenides is a person and pathway to wisdom that parallels to a great extent how I've reframed quality in *Zen* through Kristeva's *chora*. True, there are no literal caves in the novel, but a choric regression does entail an analogic descent to the intrauterine space of fetus and mother. And while neither *mares*, maidens, nor goddesses guide that regression, its final resting place, the metaphoric womb of the mother, is decidedly feminine. In *Zen* itself, the

father/narrator and Phaedrus can be seen as a dual study in incubation, where choric regression reintegrates the two “split” selves.

Finally, and perhaps most suggestively, as Rickert describes it, the surviving fragments of Parmenides’s poem itself may well be a prehistorical form of the rhetoric in *Zen*. Apparently, classical scholars could never quite reconcile the technical and tedious logical moves within the “Aletheia” section of the poem with its rather antiquated poetic style of expression. As Rickert notes, for many, the poem is “not only obscure, but bad” (475). But Rickert offers up an alternative reading that is strikingly close to what I’ve said about how the rhetoric in *Zen* transports rhetor and audience into something like a collective choric wholeness.

The poem was intended for performance: its epic hexameter verse form, intricate, dense, and confounding wordplay, and rapid argumentative pace have transportive effects, including in particular altered states of mind that mirror Parmenides’s opening image of being carried away by the gods. . . . Reasoning is certainly at work here, but it is combined with other faculties—affective, perceptive, rhetorical. Parmenides’s oneness is the realization of a fundamental interconnectedness but [is] not . . . a metaphysical oneness. Rather it is an enacted experience of incubatory oneness. It amounts to a transduction, rather than representation. (474, 487)

Rickert’s reworking of “On Being” is, I think, a fairly close analogue to the “movement of the soul” example from the *Phaedrus* that I have cited and to my more general point that choric rhetoric is inspirational, perhaps even ecstatic, and functions to unite rhetor and audience in a moment of undifferentiated wholeness.

In this final section, I’ve tried to show that when quality and rhetoric in *Zen* are reworked through Kristeva’s *chora*, what emerges is a vision of living and of rhetoric that transcends the pages of Pirsig’s novel. I’ve argued that this vision is useful for clarifying certain aspects of Davis’s own pre-discursive rhetoric of “saying,” for rethinking *anamnesis* as a form of choric regression driven by divine madness, and finally, for seeing Parmenides as a figure who perhaps practiced undifferentiated living and choric rhetoric long before anyone had “intellectualized” them.

*Department of Communication
University of Arkansas, Fayetteville*



NOTE

The author would like to dedicate this article to Thomas B. Farrell and Robert M. Pirsig.



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